Improving work outcomes for individuals and with cognitive disabilities: Explaining variation using economic and programmatic indicators in Vocational Rehabilitation

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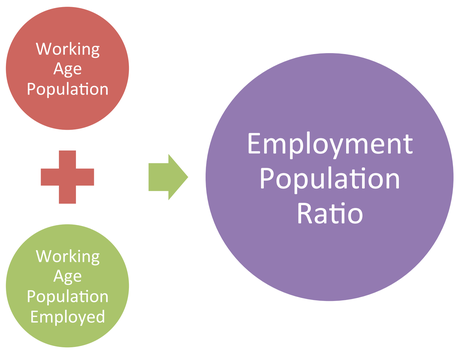
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Introduction

Problem

The 2010 American Community Survey (ACS) data indicate that a third of all people with cognitive disabilities reside in poverty (33.4%), a figure 2.5 times greater than the general population. Employment is one of the avenues to move out of poverty. Many people with cognitive disabilities opting to work turn to state Vocational Rehabilitation Services (VR) programs to help find employment. These state programs are responsible for implementing the Rehabilitation Act. A stated purpose of the Act is "To empower individuals with disabilities to maximize employment, economic self-sufficiency, independence, and inclusion and integration into society" (29 USC § 701).

Figure 1: Employment-Population Ratio



Research Questions

1. What is the general relationship between the national economic condition and the performance of employment support system in achieving employment outcomes for people with cognitive disabilities?
2. What effect do state economic conditions and state employment support system factors have on the performance of the employment support system in achieving employment outcomes for people with cognitive disabilities?

Methods

Data Sources

- Rehabilitation Services Administration's Annual Review Report (RSA-ARR)
- Current Population Survey (CPS), as reported by the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)

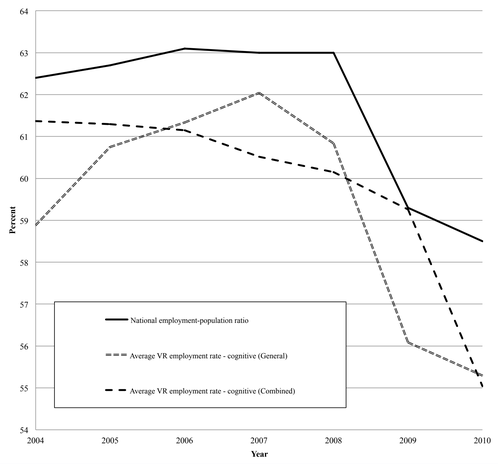
State-Level Variables

Average Cost/employment outcome
Participant to counselor ratio
Employment population ratio
New applicants/million residents
Agency type
VR employment rate-cognitive disabilities

Data Analysis

This study utilizes bivariate correlations and linear regression to describe relationships and explain the variability in state outcomes by way of a number of explanatory variables.

Employment-Population Ratio & VR Employment Rates over Time



Results

Moderate positive correlations	
State VR employment rate & State Population Ratio:	.335*
State VR employment rate & New applicants per million state residents:	.301*
New applicants per million state residents & participant-to-counselor ratio:	.404**
Moderate negative correlations	
New applicants per million state residents & Average cost per outcome:	-.305*
Participant-to-counselor ratio & Average cost per outcome:	-.310*

Two Block Regression Analysis

Block	Variables	B	SE	Sig.	
1	Intercept	7.48	19.2	.698	
	Employ.-pop. ratio	0.80	0.3	.016	*
2	Intercept	44.39	19.6	.028	*
	Employ.-pop. ratio	0.34	0.3	.264	
	Agency type	2.22	2.7	.414	
	New applicants/mill. residents	0.00	0.0	.009	**
	Avg. cost/outcome	-0.02	0.0	.027	*
	Participant:Counselor	-0.29	0.1	.001	**

Notes. 1) Dependent Variable: State VR employment rate: cognitive impairment, and 2) *p < .05, **p <.01.

•State economic conditions explain a significant amount of the variation in state VR employment rates (R^2 = .112);

•Effects of state economy dissipates after accounting for state VR programmatic factors (R^2 = .37). Possibly due to intervening role of a programmatic indicator.

Conclusions

Discussion

There is a growing demand and expectation among persons with disabilities that they will be employed. VR provides a valuable resource to job seeking individuals but in the current economic state of our nation and it may unrealistic to expect that VR bear the burden of all the responsibilities of job placement and support for individuals with disabilities. The success and inability of state VR systems in achieving employment outcomes for people with cognitive disabilities directly relates to the health of the state economy.

Future Directions

• Showcasing stories of success and providing data to support the economic contributions and social value of those living with cognitive disabilities;
•Continued use of evidenced practices in employment services;
•Efficient and effective economic development that is inclusive of people with cognitive disabilities.

References

Nord, D., Hewitt, A, and Nye-Lengerman. (in press). *Economic and Programmatic Indicators Explain Vocational Rehabilitation Employment Rates of Persons with Cognitive Disabilities*. Journal of Vocational Rehabilitation

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